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New West Symphony Strikes a High Note with Grant Awards for Youth Music Education

7 Grants Announced

New West Symphony is proud to announce that in 2025 the organization received seven grants totaling over \$80,000 from various funders across Ventura County to support the Symphony's education initiatives designed to further its mission in nurturing the next generation's creativity and imagination through transformative music education.

Local municipalities, through their respective community and event grant programs, have awarded funds to support New West Symphony's flagship education program, called Symphonic Adventures. It's series of live, interactive concerts for students from the 3rd through 5th grades.

"We appreciate the leadership of Thousand Oaks, Camarillo, Westlake Village and Agoura Hills for recognizing our education programs that enrich countless young lives through the power of the arts. Together with our municipal leaders, we are opening doors to the world of live music. These contributions, totaling over \$30,000, will help advance live, interactive concerts for youth," said New West Symphony CEO, Natalia Staneva.

Funding for Symphonic Adventures has also been provided by grants from the Meadowlark Service League, an all-volunteer organization of local women who commit substantial time and effort to focus on fundraising to meet our community needs.

The City of Ventura's Cultural Funding grant program has awarded New West Symphony a grant of \$10,000 for the Laby Harmony Project. The Laby Harmony Project is a tuition-free, after-school youth development program providing high quality music instruction to 160 students from low income families in Ventura. Through this program, the Symphony creates pathways to success for Ventura children by engaging students in a multi-year continuum of rigorous after-school music training. Through offering tuition-free, long-term, and high-quality musical opportunity in the heart of Ventura's Westside, Harmony builds social equity.

Rotary Clubs, with their enduring spirit of service and unwavering commitment to community enrichment, have played a vital role in supporting educational programs by New West

Symphony. Their unwavering commitment to nurturing young minds also resulted in grant support for the Laby Harmony Project from the Rotary Club of Ventura.

The Rotary Club of Thousand Oaks granted \$34,000 to New West Symphony to purchase a new van for the Music Van Program. The New West Symphony Music Van is a nationally acclaimed program that brings orchestral instruments to classrooms for a “hands-on” experience. This unique program is available to elementary schools throughout the year and has introduced the excitement of music making to thousands of students throughout Ventura County and the Conejo Valley. Students have had the opportunity to try a whole range of instruments from the strings, brass, wind and percussion families.

“The New West Symphony’s previous music van became inoperable after sitting idle during the pandemic,” said Pat McCoy, President of the Thousand Oaks Rotary Club. “Recognizing the importance of this program, we wanted to ensure students and communities across the County could once again experience this unique musical petting zoo and be introduced to the arts. The Thousand Oaks Rotary Club’s support of the Music Van Program not only spreads the word about Rotary’s commitment to service but also introduces children to the arts—planting seeds of creativity and compassion that will help our community flourish for years to come.”

Research shows that exposure to the arts can significantly benefit school-aged children by enhancing cognitive skills, emotional well-being and social behavior. Music education has been linked to improved academic performance, including higher SAT scores and fosters emotional regulation and social skills.

“This work would not be possible without the steadfast support of generous funders, and we are deeply grateful for their ongoing commitment to the future of music,” concluded Natalia Staneva.

About New West Symphony

Founded in 1995, the New West Symphony is a professional orchestra that draws its players from the rich talent pool of professional Los Angeles-area musicians. With artistic direction led by Grammy® winner Maestro Michael Christie, the Symphony is the resident company of the Thousand Oaks Civic Arts Plaza and performs at Rancho Campana Performing Arts Center in Camarillo. It presents six Masterpiece Series concerts annually, performing major works from the symphonic repertoire with internationally-acclaimed artists as guest soloists. The Symphony also provides quality outreach and educational opportunities for the communities it serves through its annual [Symphonic Adventures](#) concert programs for youth, its traveling [Music Van](#), and the [Laby Harmony Project](#), a year-round music and leadership program for underserved students.

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